STUDY AID · MATTHEW 5:21-48 · EPISODE 7 OF 58

Be Whole, *Like Your Father*

'Perfect' isn't flawless. It's whole, mature, blameless.

▶ Watch on YouTube | Read Matthew 5:21-48 in the LSB | 24:25 | Channel: Every Word

Full title: The Most IMPOSSIBLE Verse in the Gospels?! (Matthew 5:21-48). Series: The Gospel of Matthew Every Word (playlist of 58 videos).

FROM THE VIDEO · BACKGROUND (ADDED) · DEBATED · LSB TEXT · ◆ LOGOS FACTBOOK LINK

01 · FROM THE VIDEO

Short summary

- The teacher reads Matthew 5:21-48: six times Jesus says 'You have heard... but I say to you,' on anger, lust, divorce, oaths, retaliation and love for enemies, ending with 'you are to be perfect, as your heavenly Father is perfect' (5:48).
- The thread is personal relationships: anger with a brother, an opponent at law, lust, divorce, oaths, generosity, loving everyone. Our relationships are how we bring God's kingdom on earth.
- These are not new commands. As the new Moses, Jesus re-teaches the Torah from the heart, against the backdrop of the scribes and Pharisees (5:20).
- Jesus puts a 'fence around the Torah,' a rabbinic way of teaching, but His fence is around the heart, where sin begins. The Talmud compares public humiliation to shedding blood; Jesus goes deeper, to anger.
- 'Perfect' echoes the Hebrew tamim: blameless, whole, mature (2 Samuel 22:31; Deuteronomy 18:13; Psalm 15:2). The Bible is looking for maturity, not flawlessness.
- The lesson: God loves His enemies, sending sun and rain on the evil and the good, so in His kingdom we love our enemies too. Sons do what the Father does (John 5:19). Will you be tamim as your heavenly Father is tamim?

> *"When Jesus said that you must be perfect as your heavenly Father is perfect, He wasn't intending to make you anxious or fearful.*
>
> From the video (auto-captions, lightly cleaned)

> *"The fence that Jesus is placing forces His people to deal with what is on the inside, what is in their heart, which is where sin originates.*
>
> From the video (auto-captions, lightly cleaned)



'But I say to you' (5:22)

Gustave Doré, The Sermon on the Mount, engraving from the Doré Bible, 1866. Via Wikimedia Commons, public domain



Teaching His disciples

James Tissot, Jesus Discourses with His Disciples, 1886-1894. Brooklyn Museum via Wikimedia Commons, public domain

Read the six sayings in pairs

Each saying has two halves: 'You have heard' (what the Law said) and 'But I say to you' (where Jesus takes it). Look up each Old Testament text first, then ask the video's question: is Jesus replacing the Torah, or showing its heart?

The video reads from another English translation. Quotations on this page are from the LSB.

02 · FROM THE VIDEO · LSB TEXT

Scripture passages covered

The video reads all of Matthew 5:21-48 and names the Old Testament text behind each saying. Each link opens those verses on read.lsbible.org.

Matthew 5:21-48

Read in full: the six sayings, ending with 5:48.

Exodus 20:13-14

'You shall not murder.' 'You shall not commit adultery.'

Deuteronomy 24:1-4

Leviticus 19:12

The certificate of divorce. The video also cites Jeremiah 3:1.

Do not swear falsely by God's name (with Numbers 30:2).

Exodus 21:23-25
'Eye for eye, tooth for tooth.'

Leviticus 19:17-18
'You shall love your neighbor as yourself.'

2 Samuel 22:31
'As for God, His way is blameless': the video's first tamim text.

Deuteronomy 18:13
'You shall be blameless before Yahweh your God': the closest parallel to 5:48.

Psalm 15:1-2
'He who walks blamelessly.'

Isaiah 66:15-24
The video: Jesus' 'fiery hell' (5:22, 29) draws on the end of Isaiah.

Deuteronomy 10:17-19
God 'shows love for the sojourner.' The video also points to Psalm 146, Zechariah 7 and Malachi 3.

John 5:19
'Whatever the Father does, these things the Son also does.'

Matthew 6:1-18
Coming next (Episode 8): prayer, and a pattern in the sermon.

Key verses in the LSB

“But I say to you that everyone who is angry with his brother shall be guilty before the court”
Matthew 5:22 (LSB)

“But I say to you, love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you,”
Matthew 5:44 (LSB)

“for He causes His sun to rise on the evil and the good, and sends rain on the righteous and the unrighteous.”
Matthew 5:45 (LSB)

“Therefore you are to be perfect, as your heavenly Father is perfect.”
Matthew 5:48 (LSB)

03 · FROM THE VIDEO · LSB TEXT

You have heard… but I say to you

Six sayings, each with the Old Testament text it starts from (left) and Jesus' words (right), both in the LSB.

1 · MATTHEW 5:21-26

Murder and anger

YOU HAVE HEARD · EXODUS 20:13

“You shall not murder.”

BUT I SAY TO YOU · MATTHEW 5:22

“But I say to you that everyone who is angry with his brother shall be guilty before the court; and whoever says to his brother, ‘Raca,’ shall be guilty before the Sanhedrin; and whoever says, ‘You fool,’ shall be guilty enough to go into the fiery hell.”

FROM THE VIDEO If you bear anger in your heart, you're already on the path toward murder, because murder usually begins in anger.

BACKGROUND Then two practical scenes: leave your offering at the altar and 'first be reconciled to your brother' (5:24), and make friends quickly with your opponent at law (5:25). Reconciliation comes before worship. Matthew 5:23-26

Chrysostom: 'Do you see authority in perfection? ... Which among prophets ever spoke on this wise? ... None; but, Thus says the Lord' (Homilies on Matthew 16).

◆ Factbook: Judgment ◆ Factbook: Temple (Jewish)

2 · MATTHEW 5:27-30

Adultery and the heart

YOU HAVE HEARD · EXODUS 20:14

“You shall not commit adultery.”

BUT I SAY TO YOU · MATTHEW 5:28

“but I say to you that everyone who looks at a woman to lust for her has already committed adultery with her in his heart.”

FROM THE VIDEO The shift is from actions performed in front of others to what only God sees, the heart.

BACKGROUND The tenth commandment already reached the heart: 'You shall not covet your neighbor's wife' (Exodus 20:17). Tearing out an eye and cutting off a hand (5:29-30) is a vivid way of saying: deal ruthlessly with what leads you to sin. Exodus 20:17 Matthew 5:29-30

3 · MATTHEW 5:31-32

Divorce

IT WAS SAID · DEUTERONOMY 24:1

“and he writes her a certificate of divorce and puts it in her hand and sends her out from his house,”

BUT I SAY TO YOU · MATTHEW 5:32

“but I say to you that everyone who divorces his wife, except for the reason of sexual immorality, makes her commit adultery; and whoever marries a divorced woman commits adultery.”

FROM THE VIDEO Avoid divorce: the video points to Deuteronomy 24:1 and Jeremiah 3:1. Jeremiah 3:1

BACKGROUND Deuteronomy 24 regulates divorce rather than commands it. Later Jesus explains: 'Because of your hardness of heart Moses permitted you to divorce your wives; but from the beginning it has not been this way' (Matthew 19:8). Compare Malachi 2:16. Matthew 19:3-9 Malachi 2:14-16

4 · MATTHEW 5:33-37

Oaths

YOU HAVE HEARD · LEVITICUS 19:12

“And you shall not swear falsely by My name, so as to profane the name of your God; I am Yahweh.”

BUT I SAY TO YOU · MATTHEW 5:34

“But I say to you, make no oath at all, either by heaven, for it is the throne of God,”

FROM THE VIDEO The video lists Leviticus 19:12 and Numbers 30:2 behind this saying. Numbers 30:2

BACKGROUND 'Let your statement be, ‘Yes, yes’ or ‘No, no’' (5:37). If your word is always true, you don't need an oath to prop it up. Jesus later exposes clever oath rules in Matthew 23:16-22. Matthew 5:37 Matthew 23:16-22 James 5:12

◆ Factbook: Jerusalem

5 · MATTHEW 5:38-42

An eye for an eye

YOU HAVE HEARD · EXODUS 21:24

“eye for eye, tooth for tooth, hand for hand, foot for foot,”

BUT I SAY TO YOU · MATTHEW 5:39

“But I say to you, do not resist an evil person; but whoever slaps you on your right cheek, turn the other to him also.”

FROM THE VIDEO Forgiving others and being radically generous.

BACKGROUND In the Law, 'eye for eye' guided judges and limited revenge to fit the harm (Exodus 21:23-25; Leviticus 24:20; Deuteronomy 19:21). Leviticus 19:18 already said, 'You shall not take vengeance.' Jesus asks for more than restraint: turn the cheek, give the garment, go the second mile. Leviticus 24:19-20 Deuteronomy 19:21 Leviticus 19:18

Chrysostom on 5:39-41: 'Do you see the height of self-denial?' (Homilies on Matthew 18).

6 · MATTHEW 5:43-48

Love your enemies

YOU HAVE HEARD · LEVITICUS 19:18

“You shall not take vengeance, and you shall not keep your anger against the sons of your people, but you shall love your neighbor as yourself; I am Yahweh.”

BUT I SAY TO YOU · MATTHEW 5:44-45

“But I say to you, love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you, so that you may be sons of your Father who is in heaven”

FROM THE VIDEO The video's focus. Jewish sentiment had become tribal: love of neighbor reached only 'the sons of your people' (Leviticus 19:18). They had forgotten that God is for the outcast, the sojourner, the orphan and the widow.

BACKGROUND 'Hate your enemy' is not a command in the Law. The same chapter says of the sojourner, 'you shall love him as yourself' (Leviticus 19:34), and Exodus tells Israel to return an enemy's stray ox (Exodus 23:4-5). Leviticus 19:33-34 Exodus 23:4-5 Proverbs 25:21

Chrysostom on this last step: 'Do you see how many steps He has ascended, and how He has set us on the very summit of virtue?' (Homilies on Matthew 18).

◆ Factbook: Righteousness

> *“The fence that Jesus is placing forces His people to deal with what is on the inside, what is in their heart, which is where sin originates.*
>
> From the video

04 · FROM THE VIDEO

A fence around the heart

The video uses two Jewish sources and one prophet to show how deep Jesus goes. Jewish sources are quoted from Sefaria's English translations.



A RABBINIC WAY OF TEACHING

A fence around the Torah

📜 MISHNAH, AVOT 1:1

FENCE

“make a fence round the Torah”

FROM THE VIDEO Imagine sin as a place on a map. A fence keeps you far from it. Other rabbis did this, but Jesus' fence is not more outward rules that can be performed for others to see; it is around the heart.

BACKGROUND This saying is credited to the Men of the Great Assembly at the start of the Mishnah's tractate Avot ('Fathers'), written down around AD 200. Translation: Joshua Kulp, Mishnah Yomit (CC BY), via Sefaria.



ANGER OR HUMILIATION?

Deeper than public shame

📜 BABYLONIAN TALMUD, BAVA METZIA 58B

DEEPER

“Anyone who humiliates another in public, it is as though he were spilling blood.”

FROM THE VIDEO The Talmud, the written account of the oral Torah, says this. Jesus goes further back, to anger in the heart. Public humiliation doesn't go deep enough; it doesn't track back to the source.

DEBATED The Talmud was compiled centuries after Jesus (around AD 500). This saying is quoted there as an older teaching, so it may reflect earlier rabbis, but we cannot be sure it was taught in Jesus' day. Translation: William Davidson edition (CC BY-NC), via Sefaria.



THE FIERY HELL · MATTHEW 5:22, 29-30

Isaiah's unquenched fire

ISAIAH · ISAIAH 66:24

“Then they will go forth and look / On the corpses of the men / Who have transgressed against Me. / For their worm will not die / And their fire will not be quenched;”

JESUS · MARK 9:47-48

“it is better for you to enter the kingdom of God with one eye, than, having two eyes, to be cast into hell, where their worm does not die, and the fire is not quenched.”

FROM THE VIDEO When Jesus speaks of hell or the judgment of fire (5:22, 29), He is drawing on Isaiah 66:15 to the end of the chapter. Read Isaiah 66 alongside Matthew 5:22-30. Isaiah 66:15-16

BACKGROUND Mark's version of the eye saying quotes Isaiah 66:24 outright. 'Hell' is Gehenna, the valley of the son of Hinnom outside Jerusalem, where children had been burned to idols (Jeremiah 7:31-32). **Jeremiah 7:31-32**

◆ Factbook: Isaiah ◆ Factbook: Judgment ◆ Factbook: Jerusalem

05 · FROM THE VIDEO · LSB TEXT

Perfect means tamim

The video's answer to 'the most impossible verse': four places the Old Testament uses tamim, then 5:48 in context.



GOD IS TAMIM

His way is blameless

🛡 **2 SAMUEL 22:31 (LSB)** TAMIM

“As for God, His way is blameless; / The word of Yahweh is tried; / He is a shield to all who take refuge in Him.”

FROM THE VIDEO The Hebrew word here is tamim: blameless. And Jesus says, be like this.



THE CLOSEST PARALLEL TO 5:48

You shall be blameless

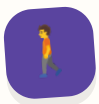
🎯 **DEUTERONOMY 18:13 (LSB)** TAMIM

“You shall be blameless before Yahweh your God.”

FROM THE VIDEO The same word: you shall be tamim before the Lord. Is the Bible setting us up for failure? No. Tamim means blameless, but also complete, mature, even innocent.

BACKGROUND It comes right before the promise of 'a prophet like me' (Deuteronomy 18:15) whom Israel must listen to. The Greek Old Testament translates tamim here with teleios, the word Matthew uses in 5:48. **Deuteronomy 18:13-15**

◆ Factbook: Book of Deuteronomy ◆ Factbook: Moses



WALK IT OUT

He who walks blamelessly

🚶 **PSALM 15:2 (LSB)** TAMIM

“He who walks blamelessly, and works righteousness, / And speaks truth in his heart.”

FROM THE VIDEO The word of God expects you to be tamim. And the psalm ends: 'He who does these things will never be shaken.'

BACKGROUND God said to Abram, 'Walk before Me and be blameless' (Genesis 17:1); Noah was 'blameless among those in his generations' (Genesis 6:9). Neither was flawless; both walked with God. **Genesis 17:1** **Genesis 6:9** **Psalm 15:5**

◆ Factbook: Book of Psalms ◆ Factbook: Abraham

IN CONTEXT · MATTHEW 5:45-48

Perfect in love

LUKE'S VERSION · LUKE 6:36

“Be merciful, just as your Father is merciful.”

MATTHEW · MATTHEW 5:48

“Therefore you are to be perfect, as your heavenly Father is perfect.”

FROM THE VIDEO This is the context of 5:48: be tamim, mature in the way you show your love, a love that reaches even the most difficult people in your circles of influence.

BACKGROUND The 'therefore' ties 5:48 to the sun and rain of 5:45. Luke's parallel puts the same idea as mercy. Luke 6:35-36

“Therefore you are to be perfect, as your heavenly Father is perfect.”

Matthew 5:48

> *“The Bible is not looking for flawlessness; it's looking for maturity.*
>
> From the video

06 · FROM THE VIDEO · LSB TEXT

Sons do what the Father does

Why loving enemies is the 'family business.'

THE FAMILY BUSINESS · MATTHEW 5:45

Sons do what the Father does

JESUS IN JOHN · JOHN 5:19

“Truly, truly, I say to you, the Son can do nothing from Himself, unless it is something He sees the Father doing; for whatever the Father does, these things the Son also does in the same manner.”

JESUS IN MATTHEW · MATTHEW 5:45

“so that you may be sons of your Father who is in heaven; for He causes His sun to rise on the evil and the good, and sends rain on the righteous and the unrighteous.”

FROM THE VIDEO In the Jewish mindset, the family business is the sons furthering the father's work. For Jesus, that business is spreading the kingdom of God on earth, and kingdom love reaches everyone, enemies included.

BACKGROUND 'Sons of God' already appeared in the Beatitudes: 'Blessed are the peacemakers, for they shall be called sons of God' (5:9). Matthew 5:9

GOD IS FOR THE OUTCAST

He shows love for the sojourner

DEUTERONOMY 10:18-19 (LSB)

REMEMBER

“He executes justice for the orphan and the widow, and shows love for the sojourner by giving him food and clothing. So show love for the sojourner, for you were sojourners in the land of Egypt.”

FROM THE VIDEO The people had forgotten that they were once outcasts themselves, slaves in Egypt, and God's clear teaching to care for the outcast, which extends to Gentiles too, some of them in this very crowd. See also Psalm 146, Zechariah 7 and Malachi 3.

Psalm 146:9 | Zechariah 7:9-10 | Malachi 3:5

◆ Factbook: Egypt



ONLY BY THE SPIRIT

A heart of flesh

EZEKIEL 36:26 (LSB) PROMISE

"Moreover, I will give you a new heart and put a new spirit within you; and I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh."

FROM THE VIDEO All of this is impossible without the Holy Spirit, replacing our hearts of stone with hearts of flesh. And some enemies, loved this way, will be transformed and adopted into God's family.

BACKGROUND 'We love, because He first loved us' (1 John 4:19). 1 John 4:19

◆ Factbook: Holy Spirit

> *"God loves His enemies; therefore in God's kingdom we should be like God and love our enemies.*
>
> From the video: the lesson for the original audience

07

Who's who in the six sayings

What the video says, then a short background note.

Jesus

VIDEO As the new Moses, gives commands that are 'nothing new': He re-teaches the Torah from the heart.

BACKGROUND 'But I say to you' six times: Jesus speaks on His own authority, which is why the crowds were astonished (7:28-29).

Matthew 7:28-29 | Deuteronomy 18:15 | ◆ Jesus Christ

The ancients

VIDEO 'You have heard that the ancients were told': the generation that received the Law, and the teaching passed down since.

BACKGROUND The LSB's 'ancients' (5:21, 33) translates archaioi, 'those of old.'

Matthew 5:21 | Matthew 5:33

The scribes and Pharisees

VIDEO The backdrop of every saying: the model of righteousness Jesus' disciples must surpass (5:20).

BACKGROUND Matthew 23 later shows their oath rules (23:16-22) and their care for small tithes while

Tax collectors and Gentiles

VIDEO Jesus' examples of people who love only those who love them back (5:46-47), people some in the crowd despised.

neglecting 'justice and mercy and faithfulness' (23:23).

Matthew 5:20 | Matthew 23:16-23 | ◆ Pharisees | ◆ Scribe

BACKGROUND Tax collectors worked for Rome or for Herod Antipas and were seen as collaborators. Matthew himself was one (9:9).

Matthew 9:9-11 | Matthew 5:46-47 | ◆ Tax collector | ◆ Gentiles

The sojourner, the orphan and the widow

VIDEO The outcasts God loves and Israel had forgotten (Deuteronomy 10; Psalm 146; Zechariah 7; Malachi 3).

BACKGROUND The Law repeatedly ties care for them to Israel's own story: 'you were sojourners in the land of Egypt' (Deuteronomy 10:19).

Deuteronomy 10:18-19 | Psalm 146:9 | ◆ Egypt | ◆ Sojourner | ◆ Widow

Moses

VIDEO Jesus is the new Moses, interpreting what was given 'from the very beginning.'

BACKGROUND Moses gave the commands Jesus quotes (Exodus 20-21; Leviticus 19; Deuteronomy 24).

Exodus 20:13-14 | Deuteronomy 24:1 | ◆ Moses

08 · BACKGROUND

Where the sermon was heard

Gold pins are background. Jesus names Jerusalem, 'the city of the great King' (5:35), far to the south.



● Named in the video ● Background

Positions of towns from their known sites; the mountain is the traditional site. Jerusalem lies about 120 km (75 miles) to the south. Coastline of the lake and rivers: OpenStreetMap contributors (ODbL); land: Natural Earth (public domain).

Mount of Beatitudes BACKGROUND

The traditional site of the sermon, above Tabgha.

◆ Factbook: Mount of Beatitudes (traditional site)

Capernaum BACKGROUND

Jesus' home base by the lake (4:13).

◆ Factbook: Capernaum

Tiberias BACKGROUND

Herod Antipas' new capital, founded around AD 20, seat of his court.

◆ Factbook: Tiberias

Magdala BACKGROUND

A busy fishing town on the west shore.

◆ Factbook: Magdala

Hippos BACKGROUND

A Gentile Decapolis city across the lake: the kind of neighbors 5:47 has in mind.

◆ Factbook: Decapolis ◆ Factbook: Hippos

Bethsaida BACKGROUND

Home town of Andrew and Peter (John 1:44).

◆ Factbook: Bethsaida

Nazareth BACKGROUND

Jesus' hometown.

◆ Factbook: Nazareth

09

Key terms

You have heard... but I say to you

VIDEO

The six sayings of 5:21-48, often called the antitheses. The video stresses they are not new law but the heart of the old.

◆ Factbook: Sermon on the Mount

Raca

BACKGROUND

An Aramaic insult, roughly 'empty-head.' Chrysostom says it shows 'some contempt and slight on the part of the speaker' (Homilies on Matthew 16).

◆ Factbook: Raca

Sanhedrin

BACKGROUND

The council: Jerusalem's highest Jewish court (LSB 5:22). Local courts sat in the towns.

◆ Factbook: Sanhedrin

Fiery hell (Gehenna)

VIDEO

From the valley of the son of Hinnom outside Jerusalem (Jeremiah 7:31-32), a picture of final judgment. The video links it to Isaiah 66.

◆ Factbook: Judgment ◆ Factbook: Gehenna

◆ Factbook: Valley of Hinnom

Quadrans

BACKGROUND

A small Roman copper coin, a quarter of an as (5:26): 'the last penny.'

Certificate of divorce

BACKGROUND

The written release in Deuteronomy 24:1 that let a divorced woman remarry.

◆ Factbook: Divorce

Go one mile

BACKGROUND

Fence around the Torah

VIDEO

'Forces' (angareuō) is a Persian loanword for compelled service: a soldier could make a civilian carry his pack. Jesus says go two.

◆ Factbook: Mile (Roman)

A rabbinic idea (Mishnah, Avot 1:1): extra rules that keep you far from breaking a command. Jesus' fence is around the heart.

◆ Factbook: Mishnah

Tamim

VIDEO

Hebrew: blameless, whole, complete, mature (H8549). The video's key to 'perfect' in 5:48.

◆ Factbook: Perfection

Oral Torah

VIDEO

The tradition of interpretation that the rabbis held was passed down alongside the written Law; later written in the Mishnah (c. AD 200) and Talmud. The video sees Jesus correcting it in this sermon.

◆ Factbook: Tradition of the elders

10 · BACKGROUND

Hebrew and Greek words

Strong's numbers match the LSB's own word tagging for the verses listed. Glosses summarize the standard lexicons; 'Look up' points you to the entry to read for yourself (BDAG for Greek; BDB or HALOT for Hebrew).

ὀργίζω

orgizō G3710

To be angry. The heart-root of murder.

Greek · Matt 5:22

ῥακά

rhaka G4469

Raca: an Aramaic term of contempt, 'empty one.'

Greek · Matt 5:22

◆ Factbook: Raca

μωρός

mōros G3474

Foolish, stupid (our 'moron'). Same root as the verb for salt that has 'become tasteless' (5:13).

Greek · Matt 5:22

γέεννα

geenna G1067

Gehenna, from Hebrew gē hinnōm, the valley of Hinnom. LSB 'hell.' Look up: BDAG, γέεννα.

Greek · Matt 5:22, 29, 30

◆ Factbook: Judgment ◆ Factbook: Gehenna

συνέδριον

synedrion G4892

Council, Sanhedrin.

Greek · Matt 5:22

◆ Factbook: Sanhedrin

ἐπιθυμέω

epithymeō G1937

To desire, long for; here, to lust. The Greek Old Testament uses it in the commandment 'You shall not covet' (Exodus 20:17).

Greek · Matt 5:28

ἀποστάσιον

apostasion `G647`

A certificate of divorce, a written release.

Greek · Matt 5:31

◆ Factbook: Divorce

πορνεία

porneia `G4202`

Sexual immorality: the one exception in 5:32. Look up: BDAG, πορνεία.

Greek · Matt 5:32

ὀμνύω

omnyō `G3660`

To swear, take an oath.

Greek · Matt 5:34

◆ Factbook: Oath

ἀγγαρεύω

angareuō `G29`

To press into service, compel (LSB 'forces'), from the Persian royal courier system.

Greek · Matt 5:41

◆ Factbook: Mile (Roman)

ἐχθρός

echthros `G2190`

Enemy, one who is hostile.

Greek · Matt 5:43, 44

ἀγαπάω

agapaō `G25`

To love: chosen, active good will, here aimed at enemies.

Greek · Matt 5:43, 44, 46

τέλειος

teleios `G5046`

Complete, mature, perfect; having reached its goal (telos). Look up: BDAG, τέλειος.

Greek · Matt 5:48

◆ Factbook: Perfection

תָּמִים

tamim `H8549`

Complete, whole, blameless, sound; used of unblemished sacrifices and of people who walk with God. Look up: BDB or HALOT, תָּמִים.

Hebrew · Deut 18:13; 2 Sam 22:31; Ps 15:2; Gen 17:1; 6:9

◆ Factbook: Perfection

אָהַב

'ahav `H157`

To love: 'you shall love your neighbor as yourself.'

Hebrew · Lev 19:18

גֵּי הִנֹּם

ge hinnom `H2011`

Hinnom, the valley south of Jerusalem: the source of the word Gehenna.

Hebrew · Jer 7:31

◆ Factbook: Jerusalem ◆ Factbook: Valley of Hinnom

◆ Factbook: Gehenna

11

Historical and cultural background

ESTABLISHED

Facts most interpreters agree on

Courts in Jesus' day

Towns had local courts of elders; Jerusalem's Sanhedrin was the high council. 'Make friends quickly with your opponent at law' (5:25) reflects how a dispute could end in debtors' prison.

Divorce debates

Jewish teachers argued over the 'indecency' of Deuteronomy 24:1. The Mishnah (Gittin 9:10) records the school of Shammai allowing divorce only for unchastity and the school of Hillel for almost any reason. Jesus' answer is closest to the strict view.

Oaths

People swore 'by heaven' or 'by Jerusalem' to sound serious while avoiding God's name. Jesus says all of these still belong to God (5:34-36), so simply tell the truth.

Roman occupation

Soldiers could legally compel civilians to carry loads for a set distance. A Roman mile was about 1,480 m (1,000 paces).

The Mishnah and Talmud

The Mishnah collects rabbinic teaching written down around AD 200; the Talmuds add later discussion (the Babylonian Talmud around AD 500). They help show how Jews read the Law, but they are later than the Gospels, so dates matter.

SOURCED

Early witnesses

> *Do you see authority in perfection? Do you see a bearing suited to a legislator? Why, which among prophets ever spoke on this wise?*
>
> John Chrysostom, c. AD 390. Homilies on Matthew 16, on 'But I say to you' (5:22). Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers, series 1, vol. 10 (public domain).

> *Do you see how many steps He has ascended, and how He has set us on the very summit of virtue?*
>
> John Chrysostom, c. AD 390. Homilies on Matthew 18, on loving enemies (5:43-48). Same source.

DEBATED

Where scholars differ

Is Jesus correcting the Law or its interpreters?

The video: Jesus re-teaches the Torah and corrects the oral tradition, not the Law itself. Others note that some sayings ('make no oath at all,' 'do not resist') go beyond what the Law required, so Jesus is fulfilling the Law by taking it further. Both agree Jesus does not set the Law aside (5:17).

What does 'perfect' mean?

Whole and mature (tamim), as the video says; or complete in love, from the context of 5:43-47; or the final goal believers grow toward. Most hold these together.

Turn the other cheek

Some read it as a call to absolute non-violence; others as personal non-retaliation that does not forbid just courts or protection of others (compare Romans 12:19-13:4). All agree it rules out revenge.

The exception clause

What 'sexual immorality' (porneia) covers in 5:32 and 19:9, and whether remarriage is allowed after a permitted divorce, are long-debated.

CAREFUL READING

Small slips in the video

Small slips worth knowing (offered gently; the video's main points stand):

- 'You shall not murder' is Exodus 20:13; the captions say 'Exodus 20:3.'
- Deuteronomy 24:1-4 regulates divorce rather than saying 'avoid divorce at all costs.' Malachi 2:16 ('For I hate divorce') is closer to that point, and Jesus explains Moses' permission in Matthew 19:8.
- The Talmud was compiled about AD 500, so its saying about public humiliation is later than Jesus (though quoted as an older teaching). The comparison still shows how deep Jesus goes.
- 'Hate your enemy' is not in the Law. Leviticus 19:18 limits 'neighbor' to 'the sons of your people,' but Leviticus 19:34 extends that love to the sojourner. The video's point about tribalism stands.
- The video says Jesus went up the mountain 'by verse 24 of chapter 4'; the crowds gather in 4:24-25, and He goes up in 5:1.
- Matthew wrote in Greek: 'perfect' is teleios. The link to tamim is real (the Greek Old Testament uses teleios for tamim in Deuteronomy 18:13), but the Hebrew word is the background, not Matthew's own word.

12 · BACKGROUND

From Sinai to the Talmud

Coral dots mark what Matthew 5:21-48 quotes or echoes. Early dates are approximate; dates tagged debated vary among scholars.

C. 1446 OR 1260 BC DEBATED

The Ten Commandments and the laws of Exodus 21

Exodus 20:13-14 *Quoted: 5:21, 27*

SAME ERA

'Love your neighbor as yourself'; love the sojourner
Leviticus 19:18 *Quoted: 5:43*

SAME ERA
'You shall be blameless before Yahweh your God'
Deuteronomy 18:13 *Echo: 5:48*

C. 700 BC
Isaiah's unquenched fire
Isaiah 66:24 *Echo: 5:22, 29*

C. AD 28 DEBATED
The Sermon on the Mount: 'But I say to you'
Matthew 5:21-48 *This episode*

C. AD 200
The Mishnah written down: 'make a fence round the Torah'
Matthew 5:17

C. AD 390
Chrysostom preaches on Matthew in Antioch
Matthew 5:22

C. AD 500
The Babylonian Talmud completed
Matthew 5:22

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Cross-references

Added cross-references for further study.

Luke 6:27-36
Luke's 'love your enemies' and 'Be merciful'
ADDED

Exodus 20:13-17
Murder, adultery, and coveting in the heart
ADDED

Leviticus 19:17-18, 33-34
Neighbor and sojourner
ADDED

Exodus 23:4-5; Proverbs 25:21-22
Helping an enemy in the Old Testament
ADDED

Romans 12:17-21
Overcome evil with good
ADDED

Matthew 19:3-9
Jesus on divorce and 'from the beginning'
ADDED

James 5:12
'Let your yes be yes'
ADDED

Genesis 17:1; 6:9
Abram and Noah: blameless (tamim)
ADDED

Isaiah 66:15-24
Fire and judgment at the end of Isaiah
ADDED

Ezekiel 36:25-27
A new heart and a new spirit
ADDED

1 John 4:19-21
We love because He first loved us
ADDED

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Reflection and discussion

0 of 6 questions marked done on this device.

1 ☐ Before this video, how did you hear 'you are to be perfect'? How does tamim (whole, mature, blameless) change it?

2 ☐ Pick one of the six sayings. What is the outward command, and what heart issue does Jesus put His 'fence' around?

3 ☐ Jesus puts reconciliation before worship (5:23-24). Is there someone you need to make peace with before you next come to worship?

4 ☐ Who is the 'enemy' or outsider in your circles of influence? What would loving and praying for them look like this week?

5 ☐ The video says sons do what the Father does. Where do you see God's 'sun and rain' kindness in your life that you could pass on?

6 ☐ Our society is 'divided, tribal, territorial and adversarial.' How can Christians model 5:43-48 online?

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Application

FROM THE VIDEO

The lesson for the original audience: God loves His enemies, so in God's kingdom we should be like God and love our enemies. Simple, but incredibly challenging. The lesson is the same today, in a society that has become so divided,

STUDY NOTE (ADDED)

Jesus gives a first step that anyone can take: 'pray for those who persecute you' (5:44). Write down one name this week and pray for that person's good every day. Then look for one

tribal, territorial and adversarial: will you love your enemies? Will you be tamim the way your heavenly Father is tamim? If you will, you will be sons and daughters of your Father in heaven. This is impossible without the Holy Spirit replacing our hearts of stone with hearts of flesh.

concrete kindness, like returning an enemy's stray ox (Exodus 23:4).

> *"Will you love your enemies? Will you be tamim the way your heavenly Father is tamim?*
>
> From the video

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Look it up in Logos

Each link opens that person, place or topic in the Logos Factbook, inside the Logos app on iPad, Mac or PC. The same links are in Copy all notes.

◆ Jesus Christ ◆ Moses ◆ Mount Sinai (Horeb) ◆ Book of Deuteronomy ◆ Pharisees ◆ Judgment
◆ Jerusalem ◆ Temple (Jewish) ◆ Isaiah ◆ Abraham ◆ Egypt ◆ Book of Psalms ◆ Holy Spirit
◆ Righteousness ◆ Kingdom of heaven ◆ Capernaum ◆ Decapolis ◆ Nazareth ◆ John Chrysostom
◆ Adultery ◆ Andrew (apostle) ◆ Anxiety ◆ The Beatitudes ◆ Bethsaida ◆ Disciples ◆ Divorce
◆ Ezekiel (prophet) ◆ Fishing ◆ Gehenna ◆ Gentiles ◆ Herod Antipas ◆ Hippos
◆ Jeremiah (prophet) ◆ Law of Moses ◆ Lex talionis ◆ Magdala ◆ Mercy ◆ Mishnah
◆ Mount of Beatitudes (traditional site) ◆ Noah ◆ Oath ◆ Tradition of the elders ◆ Perfection
◆ Persecution ◆ Prayer ◆ Book of Proverbs ◆ Raca ◆ Mile (Roman) ◆ Salt ◆ Sanhedrin
◆ Scribe ◆ Sea of Galilee ◆ Sermon on the Mount ◆ Peter (Simon Peter) ◆ Sojourner ◆ Tabgha
◆ Babylonian Talmud ◆ Tax collector ◆ Tiberias ◆ Widow ◆ Valley of Hinnom

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